No.49 Fluke

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Fluke analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Fluke by Romesh Gunesekera contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Fluke

The story begins with a description of Mr Weerakoon, a smartly dressed businessman with a "modern" computer case. He has an air of confidence and energy as he climbs into the back of a taxi. The narrator, Vasantha, the taxi driver, listens to Mr Weerakoon talk about his work. He is on his way to an important marketing meeting.

At the conference venue, Mr Weerakoon asks Vasantha to bring his bags to a meeting room signposted "Marketing: The Secret of Success". The meeting room has a view of a "pool", "coconut trees", and the "sea". But Mr Weerakoon has trouble with the overhead projector. Although Vasantha is not a "computer man", he thinks he can help. He explains that the human body has a "magnetism", and that machines "respond to their touch". It works, and Mr Weerakoon suggests the taxi driver stay to get a few tips on marketing.

As Vasantha listens to Mr Weerakoon discuss "stuff about bell curves and market segmentation", he decides it all seems over-complicated "hot air". He remembers how simple it was to set up his small transport business once he retired at 55.

At lunchtime Mr Weerakoon invites Vasantha for lunch on the "terrace". There, Vasantha strikes up a conversation with a man who used to fight in the **Sri Lankan civil war**. The man, Lucky, tells Vasantha about his new venture using disused naval ships

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Nokia". Vasantha is certain it is in the taxi, so he goes to look for it.

He finds the phone but, before he takes it back, he opens it with a pin number he says most people use. He decides to go on the terrace to close his eyes. There he contemplates the way the sea air can make one forget their troubles. He wants to tell Mr Weerakoon that marketing is easy, but the most important thing to know is how to deal with a small mistake, such as not having a secure phone. The ambiguous ending implies that "common sense" and peace of mind is the best way to achieve success.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Fluke

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Romesh Gunesekera's Fluke.

What are the key themes in Fluke?

Theme	Analysis

Individual identity	• Contrasting characters emphasise key differences between the lifestyles of Vasantha and the people he meets:
	  ○ Mr Weerakoon is a "modern" entrepreneur who is "flustered" and preoccupied with his laptop and phone
	  ○ Vasantha has a modest but successful business with no need for marketing or complex technology
	  ○ He does "what I love"
	• Gunsekera implies modern versions of success create emotional turmoil and complications:
	  ○ Mr Weerakoon is reckless with important information and becomes distressed at every small hurdle

Help me understand

	the war

The natural world	• The story contrasts an over-complicated modern life with a traditional, peaceful life watching the "sea" "under the trees"
	• Vasantha thinks about the whales and how separated they are from human plans, and he refers to Japanese whaling:
	  ○ The title of the story has a double meaning: it can refer to luck, and the shape of whales' fins
	• Gunesekera raises modern concerns about the natural world:
	  ○ Vasantha's passengers worry about climate change and tell him their "eco-preferences"
	• Gunesekera highlights changes in Sri Lanka through contrasts between nature and the built environment:
	  ○ Through the conference centre window you could "just about glimpse the sea"
	  ○ There is a meeting room full of "hot air" and a "terrace" with a "soothing" sea breeze

Reality and illusion	• The story presents the illusion of confidence through Mr Weerakoom who speaks "loudly" and is "bursting with energy"
	• But Guneskera reveals how insecure and foolish he is:
	  ○ He loses his "Brand-new" phone which he says is a "Big, big disaster" and he cannot fix the projector
	  ○ He carries a "pretend leather" briefcase
	• In contrast, Vasantha is a small business owner who is insightful and unassuming:
	  ○ He cares nothing for "rank"
	  ○ Ironically, Vasantha ends the story with the upper hand

Writer's methods in Fluke

How does Gunesekera present his ideas and perspectives?

In the short story Fluke by Romesh Gunesekera, the thoughts of an elderly taxi driver reflect the changing nature of a war-torn Sri Lanka, and the meaning of success in a modern world.

First-person narrator	• Using a first-person narrator, Gunesekera presents the perspective of an elderly taxi driver to show alternative attitudes to modern life:
	  ○ Vasantha is humble and polite to his passengers
	  ○ But his monologue reveals strong opinions:
	  ▪ He does not "give a toss about social standing or net worth"
	  ○ He is also witty:
	  ▪ He describes Lucky as "the navy's latest secret weapon for commercial supremacy" "settled on a lounger"
	• Guneskera is able to raise themes about tradition and modernity by showing the thoughts of a retired man, Vasantha:
	  ○ He sees himself as disconnected from the "brand-new face of our remodelled country"

Symbolism	• To explore themes about the natural world, Gunesekera uses natural imagery to symbolise peace:
	  ○ Outside, the sea breeze is "making music with the trees"
	  ○ Sibilance draws attention to nature as timeless and slow-paced:
	  ▪ The "sea keep[s] the same soft time"
	  ○ Vasantha lets the sea air help him to "sleep like old people whose memories have finally receded and left them in peace"
	• This is juxtaposed with the modern, technological world where the men are "half-throttled by their plump polyester ties":
	  ○ The laptop case symbolises the constancy of work in a modern world and represents Mr Weerakoon's reliance on technology
	  ○ Mr Weerakoon repeatedly "patted the bag as if it were a pet"
	  ○ Phones are "nursing secrets, aching to spill the beans": the personification presents them as threatening
	• Gunesekera contrasts a humble life with the desire for wealth with the use of traditional and modern symbols:
	  ○ Vasantha uses his "good chi" to solve technological issues, which

	to expensive brands when he asks Vasantha to get his "Gucci" flowing

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners recommend you form a personal and evaluative response in answer to the question. They suggest you use your introductory paragraph to introduce an argument or thesis statement that presents your own interpretation of the writer's ideas and perspectives.

It is best not to simply provide biographical and historical information about the writer in your introduction paragraph. Instead, use this to showcase your interpretation of the story. For example, you could write, "Gunesekera sets his short story Fluke in war-torn Sri Lanka to present an elderly man's perspective on a changing world".

Fluke key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to use your knowledge of the story in the question to inform your interpretation. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid evidence.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Romesh Gunesekera's Fluke, arranged by the following themes:

- **Individual identity**
- **The natural world**
- **Reality and illusion**

Individual identity

> **"I do whatever my customer wants me to do. That's the key. It is no big secret" — Vasantha**

Meaning and context

- Vasantha, the taxi driver, has a simple approach to his business
- He says he does what he is told by his customers

Analysis

- He is presented as independent and self-assured

> **"Whatever your foibles, your wanton misdeeds, you can dream of new ventures and be a success if you can sleep easy. It can't be that difficult" — Vasantha**

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha is closing his eyes on the terrace, he thinks about his many problems and reflects on people's weaknesses and mistakes
- Vasantha considers the idea of worry, stress, and, perhaps, guilt
- He decides that if you can "sleep easy" there is always hope for the future and a chance for new plans

Analysis

- Implicitly, Gunesekera shows how Vasantha faces a moral dilemma:
  - He has seen Mr Weerakoon's "secrets" on his phone and reflects on whether he should make use of this information, offer him advice, or do nothing
- Vasantha reflects on human nature and concludes that peace of mind is the best way to achieve real success

The natural world

> **"Someone once told me that the human body has magnetism in it, and with some people the flow is such that machines respond to their touch" — Vasantha**

Meaning and context

- When Mr Weerakoon has problems with the projector, Vasantha helps him
- He says that humans have the power to use magnetic energy on machines

Analysis

- Gunesekera highlights ideas about spirituality and individual success
- He refers to energy throughout his story:
  - At first it is the bustling energy of Mr Weerakoon
  - This is later shown to be nervous energy
- Vasantha's "good **chi**" refers to the flow of energy that connects humans to all other things, a magnetic energy that brings peace and good fortune

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha sits outside to reflect, he thinks about the whales
- He has just heard that Lucky plans to use naval ships to take tourists whale watching, and he wonders if the whales know

Analysis

- Gunesekera's narrator is witty:
  - His **wry** comment highlights the lack of involvement of whales, and, thus, the natural world, in human plans
- The word "schemes" suggests the plans are devious, and, perhaps, exploitative

Reality and illusion

> **"Like he is bursting with energy, which I imagine impresses his clients who are in need of gurus with vitality" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Vasantha, the narrator, describes his passenger, Mr Weerakoon, as someone full of "energy" and life
- He thinks this is sure to make him appear like he knows what he is talking about:
  - He thus appears like a "guru", a Hindu spiritual leader

Analysis

- Gunesekera creates a humorous take on modern life by showing Vasantha's cynical perspective on a modern world:
  - The entrepreneur, Mr Weerakoon, is compared to someone exploding with restlessness
- The narrator mocks him using a religious reference to "gurus", and implies that his show of confidence does not translate to real expertise

> **"These days it is so hard to spot a fake" — Vasantha**

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha sees a "bird" in the conference centre, he has to check to make sure it is a statue, not a real bird
- He thinks so many things are "fake" copies in the modern world

Analysis

and that something genuine is hard to find

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.

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